

South Korea: Rebound in Early May Exports, Driven by Semiconductors

Bottom line:

Korea's per-workday exports in the first 20 days of May rose 2.8% mom sa, rebounding from -2.5% the prior month. Total exports during the 20 days gained 8.7% mom sa on positive workday effects, posting a record high pace of 64.8% yoy. Semiconductor exports extended an 8-month streak of increase at an accelerated pace of 11.9% and accounted for roughly half of the headline sequential increase. Exports to Taiwan and mainland China gained the most, by 20.6% and 10.4% respectively and accounted for roughly 40% of the headline gains. Total imports during the 20 days rebounded to 6.7% mom sa, with around half of the gains accounted for by energy-related products. The trade surplus (not seasonally adjusted) widened from US\$10.5bn to US\$11bn, the second largest on record.

Key numbers:

May 20 days' exports, adjusted for workday differences: +2.8% mom sa vs. previous: -2.5% mom sa

May 20 days' imports, adjusted for workday differences: -0.4% mom sa vs. previous: +0.4% mom sa

May 20 days' trade balance: +US\$11.0bn vs. previous: +US\$10.5bn

Main points:

1. Korea's per-workday exports in the first 20 days of May rose 2.8% mom sa, rebounding from -2.5% the prior month ([Exhibit 1](#)). Total exports during the 20 days gained 8.7% mom sa on positive workday effects. On a year-on-year basis, total exports during the 20 days posted a record high pace of 64.8%, accelerating from 49.4% the prior month.

2. Semiconductor exports extended an 8-month streak of increase at an accelerated pace of 11.9% and accounted for roughly half of the headline sequential increase. Among other tech exports, increases in exports of household appliances were offset by losses in computers and handsets. Non-tech exports rebounded modestly to +3.1%, up from -10.8% the prior month, led by gains in steel, autos, and auto parts.

3. Exports to Taiwan and mainland China gained the most, by 20.6% and 10.4% mom sa respectively and accounted for roughly 40% of the headline gains. Exports to the US also posted robust momentum of 7.0%, whereas exports to the EU continued to rise at a modest pace of 2.0%. Exports to Japan fell more rapidly from last month, by 10.6%.

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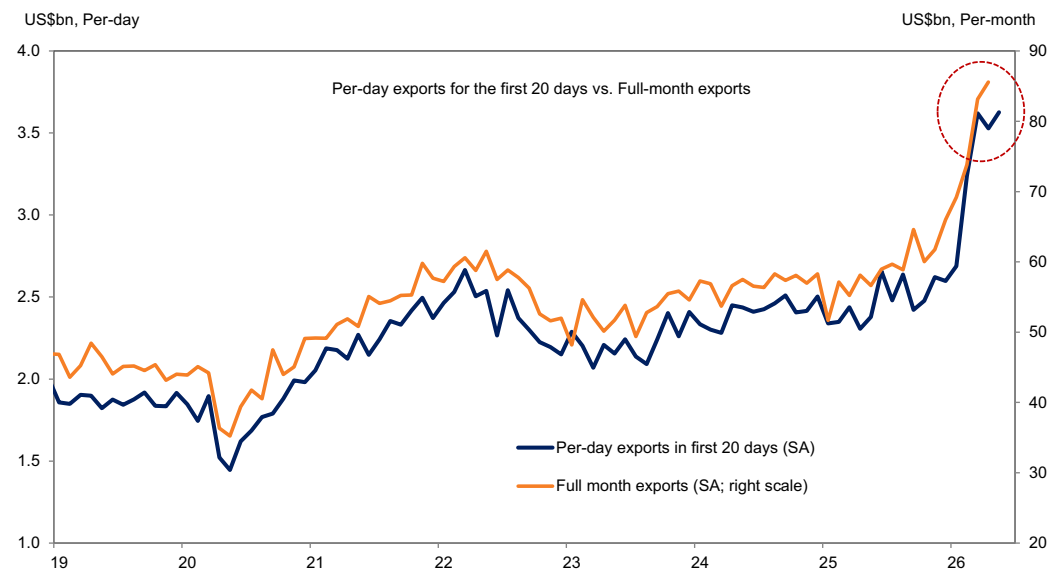
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4. Total imports during the 20 days rebounded to 6.7% mom sa, up from -1.0% the prior month. Around half of the gains accounted for by energy products including crude oil and petroleum products, which together rebounded to 15.8%. Imports of semiconductor producing equipment also accelerated to 21.3%, recording the strongest momentum since September last year. The trade surplus (not seasonally adjusted) widened from US\$ 10.5bn in April to US\$ 11bn, the second largest on record.

Exhibit 1: Rebound in early May exports



Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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